6.5

Pressure Groups

Cambridge IGCSE Business

- What Are Pressure Groups?
- Methods of Influence
- Boycotts
- Media Campaigns
- Legal Action
- Business Responses
- Evaluation

Pressure Groups

Pressure groups represent the interests of citizens, consumers, workers or the environment. They can force powerful businesses to change their behaviour — sometimes dramatically.

- Explain what pressure groups are and why they exist
- Describe methods pressure groups use to influence businesses
- Explain how businesses respond to pressure group activity
- Evaluate the impact of pressure groups on businesses

Pressure Groups and Their Methods

Who they are · What they do · Real cases

What Are Pressure Groups and Why Do They Exist?

A pressure group is an organised group of people who try to influence the policies of businesses or governments to promote a cause or protect the interests of their members.

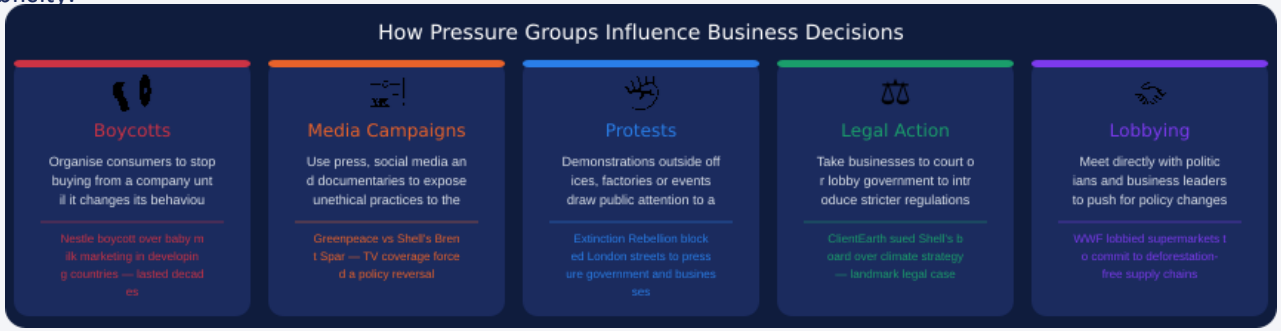
Main types of pressure group:

Environmental	Protect the natural environment from business and government activity	*Greenpeace · Friends of the Earth · WWF · Extinction Rebellion*
Consumer	Protect consumers from unfair prices, unsafe products and misleading claims	*Which? · Citizens Advice · Fairer Finance*
Workers' rights	Protect employees from exploitation, unsafe conditions and unfair pay	*Trade unions: Unite, GMB, Unison · TUC (Trades Union Congress)*
Animal welfare	Protect animals from cruelty in farming, testing and entertainment	*PETA · RSPCA · Humane Society*
Single-issue	Campaign on one specific issue or against one specific company	*Stop the Badger Cull · Anti-fur campaigns · Just Stop Oil*

Exam tip: Pressure groups exist because individuals alone cannot influence large businesses or governments. By organising, they gain collective power to challenge decisions that affect their cause.

Methods Pressure Groups Use to Influence Businesses

Pressure groups use a range of tactics — from peaceful campaigns and legal action to direct confrontation. The most effective are those that create widespread negative publicity.



Comparing methods by effectiveness and disruption:

Method	Speed	Impact on business	Risk to pressure group
Boycott	Slow — builds over months	Revenue loss, reputation damage	Needs mass participation to be effective
Social media campaign	Fast — can go viral overnight	Massive reputational damage quickly	Counter-campaigns, legal threats from business
Protests / demonstrations	Immediate — visible disruption	Disrupts operations, generates news	Arrests, public sympathy may shift
Legal action	Slow — years in courts	Forces policy change, sets legal precedent	Expensive, uncertain outcome
Lobbying	Slow — policy change takes time	Long-term regulation change	Access requires resources and connections

Exam tip: Social media has transformed pressure group power. What once took months through traditional media can now reach millions overnight — making reputational damage much faster and harder to control.

How Businesses Respond to Pressure Groups

Businesses cannot always ignore pressure groups — especially when campaigns damage sales, recruitment or share price. How they respond shapes long-term reputation and strategy.

Business response strategies:

Change behaviour

Act on the pressure group's concerns — change products, policies or supply chains

Shell reversed plans to dump Brent Spar oil platform after Greenpeace campaign

Public dialogue

Meet with the group, acknowledge concerns and demonstrate commitment to improvement

McDonald's met with environmental groups to redesign packaging and sourcing

Legal action

Take pressure group to court for defamation, trespass or economic damage

McDonald's sued Helen Steel and Dave Morris over 'McLibel' leaflets in 1990

PR campaign

Counter negative publicity with positive messaging about ethical commitments

BP rebranded to 'Beyond Petroleum' after pressure over oil spill damage

Ignore

Continue operations unchanged — only viable if financial impact is minimal

Fast fashion brands often ignore ethical criticism while sales remain strong

Exam tip: Legal action by businesses against pressure groups is risky — it can generate more negative publicity than the original campaign. McDonald's McLibel case backfired, becoming the longest UK trial in history.

Evaluating the Impact of Pressure Groups on Businesses

Pressure groups play an important role in holding businesses accountable. But their impact depends on the issue, the methods used, and how much public and media support they attract.

Ways Pressure Groups Benefit Society

- Expose unethical practices that businesses and governments prefer to hide
- Force businesses to internalise external costs they would otherwise ignore
- Give consumers information to make ethical purchasing decisions
- Drive meaningful policy change — often faster than government action
- Create accountability for powerful corporations that face few other checks

Criticism of Pressure Group Activity

- Some tactics cause economic harm — job losses, supply disruption, higher costs
- May be undemocratic — a minority imposing views on the majority
- Extremist groups risk public backlash that undermines the cause
- May target the wrong businesses — large firms while smaller ones continue
- Can be based on incomplete or misleading information — emotionally driven

Evaluation — how much power do pressure groups have?

Pressure groups are most effective when they: (1) attract large-scale public support, (2) generate sustained media coverage, (3) can demonstrate direct financial harm (e.g. falling sales, declining share price). Large MNCs with strong brand loyalty are most vulnerable to reputational campaigns. Small, local businesses are often unaffected by national pressure group activity.

Exam tip: Always link the power of a pressure group to the BUSINESS TYPE. A premium brand like John Lewis is far more vulnerable to ethical pressure than a discount retailer competing purely on price.

Key Revision Checklist – 6.5 Pressure Groups

What they are	Organised groups that try to influence business or government decisions to promote a cause or protect members
Types	Environmental (Greenpeace), consumer (Which?), workers (trade unions), animal welfare (PETA), single-issue
Boycotts	Organise consumers to stop buying from a company. Slow to build but can cause significant revenue loss.
Media campaigns	Use press and social media to expose unethical practices. Fast and powerful — can go viral overnight.
Protests	Demonstrations outside premises. Immediate disruption and news coverage. Risk of arrests.
Legal action	Take businesses to court. Slow and expensive — but can force policy change and set legal precedent.
Lobbying	Meet politicians and executives directly. Slow but can result in long-term regulatory change.
Business response	Change behaviour · public dialogue · legal action · PR counter-campaign · ignore
Evaluation	Most effective when there is wide public support, sustained media coverage and measurable financial impact